



Golden breakthrough: India head coach Amol Muzumdar praised his team's resilience and called the World Cup win a 'watershed moment' for women's cricket. PTI

struggle to rotate strike. With more prolific batting opponents waiting, coach Muzumdar looked visibly pensive even after India skittled Pakistan for 159 in a chase of 248.

Against the Proteas, India huffed and puffed again to manage 251. The top six couldn't find rhythm after the PowerPlay, with left-arm spin once again hurting the side. Like

Inoka Ranaweera and Sadia Iqbal before, Chloe Tryon and Nonkululeko Mlaba proved tricky.

After a worrying 127 dots against Sri Lanka and 173 against Pakistan, India racked up 185 against South Africa. A lower-order rescue followed once more, built on the back of Richa Ghosh's 77-ball 94.

The bowlers set India up for assured victory. The first four Protean wickets fell for just 58 runs. However, India perhaps got prematurely comfortable about a win that was yet to be sealed, and Tryon and Nadine de Klerk extracted a hefty penalty. De Klerk was a

woman possessed as she smacked a career-best unbeaten 84 off just 54 balls to put a seesawing fixture to rest in her side's favour. Gaud's inexperience showed, and even the seasoned Sneha Rana and Deepti weren't spared as the game slipped out of India's hands.

Soon, Australia came calling. Asked to bat first again, India needed to fight to counter an Australian order that nearly bats all the way through. Smriti found form with a stylish 66-ball 80, while Pratika Rawal stepped up as the aggregator. But Smriti's dismissal meant Pratika — a classically unrushed ODI player — paired with a slower Harleen Deol.

This wasn't a new problem. Even in the series in the run-up to the World Cup, Smriti and Pratika scored at over six runs an over, while Pratika and Harleen managed just over four. Their collective strike rates hovered in the 60s, not ideal against top teams with considerable firepower in the batting order. So much so, it was beneficial for opponents to keep this pair in the middle rather than dismissing them.

Against Australia, cameos from Harmanpreet Kaur, Jemimah, and Richa Ghosh, and a massive extras count helped India to 330, 20 runs short of where it was headed.

India's decision to stick with just five bowling options cost the side. Left-arm spinner Charani was the lone bright spot, showing immaculate control and aggression as she took three wickets for just 41 runs in a high-scoring match. Gaud was expensive, as was Sneha. India didn't field Renuka Singh, as it would mean going in a batter short.

Since Muzumdar took over in 2023, India has preferred the five-bowler set-up while encouraging the top order to find skills with the ball. That experiment saw Smriti roll her arm in a few fixtures across both white-ball formats. Pratika, a handy off-spinner, was not deployed. Harmanpreet, a handy wicket-taker, too, didn't take the plunge on a batting-friendly wicket as Australia registered the highest successful chase in women's ODIs. Persistent slip-ups in the field did not help the